Rare Orange 'Pumpkin Spice' Baby Loggerhead Turtle Spotted in Florida

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Fall decorations showed up early in stores this yearand so did an unusually colorful baby sea turtle. In August, Florida resident Michael Landress saw a **loggerhead hatchling** (Caretta caretta) hurrying toward the ocean. Its shell had an earthy autumn tint. "'Pumpkin Spice' sprang to mind as the little orange **hatchling** raced to its ocean home," Landress wrote to Popular Science, even though he says he does not like pumpkin spice drinks or pie.

Most **loggerhead hatchlings** have dark-to-light brown top shells, called the **carapace**, and flippers that are dark with paler edges. Their bottom shell, the **plastron**, is usually tan or faded yellow, said Daniel Evans, a biologist at the Sea Turtle Conservancy. Colors as bold as "pumpkin spice," or albino turtles, are rare.

Color matters for **camouflage**. **Hatchlings** hide in floating seaweed mats such as **sargassum**. Typical browns blend in; odd colors stand out more to predators, Evans explained. That is likely why adults rarely show such dramatic **hatchling** color differences. Adult **loggerheads** usually have reddish-brown **carapaces** and pale yellowish undersides.

Loggerheads are named for their large heads. They live in subtropical and temperate seas, and Florida hosts one of the world's largest nesting groups. Still, the IUCN lists them as Endangered, and the United States lists them as Threatened. A major danger is accidental catch in commercial fishing gear.

The pumpkin-spice **hatchling** offers a gentle seasonal wonder: nature's palette can surprise even people who spend lots of time on Florida beaches.

Word Treasure

loggerhead -- A kind of sea turtle named for its large head.
hatchling -- A newly hatched baby animal, here a baby turtle.
carapace -- The hard top shell of a turtle.
plastron -- The flatter bottom shell on a turtle's underside.
camouflage -- Coloring or patterns that help an animal blend into its surroundings.
sargassum -- Floating seaweed mats where young turtles can hide.

Background you need

Loggerhead sea turtles hatch on beaches and crawl toward the ocean soon after emerging.

A hatchling's shell colors can help it hide among floating seaweed.

Unusual colors are rare because animals that stand out may be easier for predators to spot.

Conservation groups track nesting beaches because these turtles still face serious threats.

Break it down

LEAD: Rare orange loggerhead hatchling nicknamed Pumpkin Spice in Florida
KEY EVENT: Beachgoer sees unusually colored baby racing to the ocean
+- EXPERT: Daniel Evans explains typical vs. rare colors
+- WHY COLOR MATTERS: Camouflage in sargassum seaweed
CONTEXT: Loggerhead biology and conservation status
THREAT NOTE: Bycatch in commercial fisheries
TONE: Seasonal wonder without inventing new facts

Why it matters

Unusual animals spark curiosity about wildlife and why camouflage and conservation matter for species that share Florida beaches.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of turtle hatchling was spotted?

(A) A penguin
(B) A desert tortoise only
(C) A crocodile
(D) A loggerhead

2. Who nicknamed it 'Pumpkin Spice'?

(A) Michael Landress
(B) A ship captain
(C) Daniel Evans
(D) A weather satellite

3. What does Daniel Evans say about unusual hatchling colors?

(A) They mean the turtle is a fish
(B) They are rare
(C) They are the most common colors
(D) They only appear in winter snow

4. Why does coloration matter for hatchlings?

(A) It changes the tides
(B) It teaches them math
(C) It powers rocket engines
(D) Camouflage while hiding in seaweed

5. What is a carapace?

(A) A beach umbrella
(B) A turtle's top shell
(C) A fishing net
(D) A type of sandwich

6. What status do conservation listings give loggerheads in the article?

(A) Unprotected garden pets
(B) Endangered (IUCN) and Threatened (U.S.)
(C) Extinct everywhere
(D) Only found in zoos

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Michael Landress: Described the autumn-toned hatchling and coined the pumpkin-spice nickname.

2. Daniel Evans: Explains typical loggerhead colors and why unusual colors are rare and riskier for camouflage.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):